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Moral panic about sexual promiscuity: Heterogeneous scales in the identification of one middle-school Latina girl[☆]

Katherine Clonan-Roy, Catherine R. Rhodes*, Stanton Wortham

University of Pennsylvania, United States

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ABSTRACT

Drawing on data from ten years of ethnographic research in a New Latino Diaspora town, this article analyzes how heterogeneous resources become relevant to the social identification of one Latina middle school girl as sexually promiscuous. We describe how the focal girl, her parents, teachers, family members, and peers mobilize resources from several different scales as they position her. Following Latour (2005) and drawing on linguistic anthropological accounts of heterogeneous resources across scales (Agha, 2007; Wortham, 2012), we describe the networks and trajectories across which one identity is produced.

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Marshall Middle School (MMS) Latino Community Liaison: “Many Latina girls date much older boys, which leads them to negative behaviors and holds them back from academic success.” (Interview, 06/12/12)

MMS 8th Grade Latina Girl: “Everybody thinks that Latina girls are sluts. But that is not the truth; I’m still a virgin!” (Personal communication, 07/15/14)

MMS Administrator: “Mexican girls assimilate too quickly, which causes them to initiate sexual activity at earlier ages”. (Fieldnote, 12/19/11)

Characterizations of Latina girls circulate through Marshall Middle School (MMS) in Marshall, a “New Latino Diaspora” (NLD) town that has only recently become home to Mexican immigrants (Gouveia, Carranza, & Cogua, 2005; Hamann, Wortham, & Murillo, 2002; Zúñiga & Hernández-León, 2005). In this town and beyond, Latina girls are often perceived as promiscuous and likely to make poor choices about sexual relations, drop out of school, become teenage mothers, or girlfriends of gang members (COSSMHO, 1999; Denner & Guzman, 2006). Most Latina girls do not in fact behave in these ways, and characterizations shift depending on the context (Denner & Guzman, 2006; Suárez-Orozco & Suárez-Orozco, 2002; Wortham, Mortimer, & Allard, 2009). At MMS, however, staff and students often employ these stereotypes of Latina identities (see De Costa and Dong & Blommaert, this issue, for other implications of scaling processes on people’s identity positioning). Such characterizations of Latina girls as sexually promiscuous can strongly influence their identity development, educational outcomes, and future successes. In this article we tell the story of one Latina girl and develop an account of how and why

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* Corresponding author.
E-mail address: rhodesc@gse.upenn.edu (C.R. Rhodes).

Latinas are being socially identified in this way, describing the heterogeneous resources that help constitute her social identification as sexually promiscuous.

Marshall is a suburban town of about 35,000 in the Northeastern U.S. that has only recently become home to large numbers of Latinos, the majority of them Mexican. Over the past two decades, the percentage of residents of Mexican origin in Marshall grew from less than 3% to almost 30%. This rapid growth has drastically changed student demographics in Marshall schools. In 20 years, the Latino population in the school district has increased from 2% to 28% (Wortham et al., 2009). Such rapid demographic changes have been seen across other parts of the NLD, and this has led to situations in which educators struggle to serve language learners and to understand unfamiliar students (Hamann et al., 2002). At MMS, staff have struggled to understand and support Latina adolescents in particular. Educators often claim that some Latina MMS students confront unique emotional challenges, have lots of conflict within their peer groups, date older boys, have sex, become pregnant at earlier ages than other girls, and are victims of sexual abuse more frequently. To address these concerns, MMS administrators asked Clonan-Roy to create a group for Latina girls to support them in dealing with these challenges in productive ways.

Drawing on ten years of ethnographic research in Marshall and three years of girls groups at MMS, in this article we describe how Latina girls are socially identified in MMS and analyze how people bring together resources from multiple scales in order to accomplish this social identification. The social and natural worlds provide heterogeneous resources that contribute both to events of social identification and to life trajectories. Any individual can claim or be assigned membership in various groups, which emerge at different spatial and temporal scales, and resources for social identification are often combined in novel ways to yield unexpected identities. To account for the trajectories of identification that any individual actually travels, analysts must determine which configurations of resources become relevant in any focal case. Of the many resources that might be relevant to identifying an individual, event or setting, only some end up playing a role for a given individual (Wortham & Rhodes, 2013). We illustrate this contingent process by describing how one Latina girl was positioned and positioned herself during her middle school years. We describe family interactions, educational practices, local community characteristics and national discourses that played an important role in her social identification. The focal girl, together with her family, peers, teachers, and other actors, mobilized contingent, heterogeneous resources from various scales and established a trajectory of identification across which this girl became identified as sexually promiscuous.

Resources, scales, networks and trajectories

In this article we ask: What resources, drawn from which spatial and temporal scales, contribute to the social identification of one Latina girl at MMS? How do we know what resources are relevant in this case? We answer these questions by drawing on Latourian (2005) network theory, cross-event theories of language and social relations (Agha, 2007; Agha & Wortham, 2005; Wortham, 2006), and theories of scales (Blommaert, 2007, 2010; Blommaert, Westinen, & Leppänen, 2014; Goebel, 2009; Hult, 2010; Lemke, 2000; Lempert, 2012).

“Resources” are anything that can become relevant to a focal process—in our case the social identification of an individual across months and years in one school. Resources can be diverse semiotic artifacts, such as widely circulating stereotypes, more local knowledge, laws, customs, taste preferences, languages, etc. We will present concrete examples in the case study below. Not all potential resources are relevant to any given process of social identification, nor can the relevant resources be known a priori (Lempert, 2012). Analysts must determine which of many possible relevant resources in fact play central roles in the focal process (Wortham, 2012; Wortham & Rhodes, 2013).

We understand “scale,” following Blommaert (2007), as a vertical, hierarchical, power-laden ordering of social space-time. Scale is both temporal and spatial. Following Blommaert et al.’s (2014) more recent work on scale, we also recognize that it is semiotic—scale is “semiotized space and time” (p. 5). In a school, for instance, many processes take place across an academic year and within a classroom: Students develop identities as diligent or resistant, teachers present curriculum, and students learn themes from that curriculum, etc. This is a relatively restricted spatial scale and an intermediate temporal scale. As Lemke (2000) argues, processes in the human world inevitably draw on resources from across scales. Learning curricular themes across an academic year, for example, also depends on longer timescale processes through which curriculum is developed, including enduring power relations in the construction and legitimation of knowledge. And it depends on more local norms about how teaching should proceed in a particular school, academic department, or special program. Almost no significant human process draws only on one or two timescales. We have argued elsewhere that social scientists must move beyond “macro-micro analyses,” which focus only on allegedly homogeneous “macro” social processes together with “micro” events (Wortham 2006, 2012; Wortham & Rhodes, 2012). The resources relevant to human processes are contingent and heterogeneous. The resources that do the work of constituting a given process come from different configurations of scales for different processes, and often for different instances of those processes. Instead of assuming that we can understand any instance of a given process—like the social identification of Latina adolescents in New Latino Diaspora towns—by citing the same set of resources, we must explore for each case the contingent, heterogeneous set of resources that are actually involved.

From a linguistic anthropological point of view, speech events are crucial to processes of social identification. A speech event involves a sender communicating a message to a receiver, on some topic, through some channel (like speech, but also including nonverbal semiotic resources), in some code (like English), in some spatiotemporal location (Hymes, 1962). Resources from other spatiotemporal scales always enable and constrain a speech event. Participants and analysts cannot understand or react coherently to acts within a speech event without presupposing models of or habits developed across

longer timescales (Wortham & Rhodes, 2012). The positions and models established in speech events can also be taken up and presupposed in subsequent events, forming chains of events across which social relations are established (Agha, 2007). Social identification generally takes place across events, as inter-event trajectories emerge and solidify (Agha, 2007; Agha & Wortham, 2005; Wortham, 2006; Wortham & Reyes, 2015). Social identification thus often involves resources from several scales, like events of identification, a trajectory of events across which one is identified, institutionalized structures and events, familial expectations, and widely circulating cultural models and habits. (See De Costa, this issue, for a related application of Lemke's timescales to trace social identification.)

We conceptualize this process using Latourian (2005) network theory, which posits networks of “assemblages” that are heterogeneous in both scale and type. Latour emphasizes that no particular process, scale, or resource is always relevant to making sense of any particular object. He argues that analysts must not limit themselves to certain characteristics of “shape, size, heterogeneity and combination of associations in the network” (p. 11). These should emerge from the particular analysis, not be determined a priori (Latour, 2005). Scollon and Scollon (2004) propose a related theory—“nexus analysis”—that also focuses on how social phenomena are accomplished through heterogeneous resources across different timescales. Both of these theories raise an important question: Given that many resources might potentially be relevant, how do we know which resources are crucial to any particular case? We address this theoretical issue in detail elsewhere, describing how participants come to presuppose certain resources and not others (Wortham & Rhodes, 2013). In the case study that follows, we apply our approach and illustrate how an analyst can differentiate resources relevant to social identification.

Socially identifying Sara as a promiscuous girl

Our ten years of ethnographic work in Marshall and three years of work with girls in the MMS girls' group have given us data on many resources that might contribute to identifying Latina girls as sexually promiscuous. Since 2005, our research team has conducted observations and interviews in schools across the Marshall School District, in churches, non-profits, community centers, and participants' homes. These data provide information about the town, the school district, the history of Latino migration, and how narratives about immigrants circulate in Marshall. This article draws on observations and interviews conducted with Latina MMS students during and outside of Latina girls' group sessions, as well as social media interactions. Since January 2012, Clonan-Roy has led girls' groups for fifth through eighth grade girls. Each group has 8–12 girls and meets weekly for an hour after school. Since 2012, Clonan-Roy has worked with 68 Latina girls in these groups. All of the girls are Latina and the vast majority are 1.5 or first generation Mexican immigrants. In what follows, we describe how one girl, whom we call “Sara,” came to be identified as sexually promiscuous.

Our analysis presents a network of relevant resources that contribute to Sara's emerging social identification, drawn from five different scales. The first scale involves broader social resources, including cultural models of family and schooling in the U.S. and Mexico, as well as gendered and racialized stereotypes of Latina girls. The second scale includes resources found at the school: ideas about academics at MMS; staff, parents', and students' aspirations for academic success and the unique climate of the Marshall School District. Relevant resources at the third scale involve Sara's family, including beliefs and practices about sexuality, family composition and child rearing. The fourth scale involves resources related to Sara's peers, such as narratives, “drama” (Latina participants' emic concept that encompasses fighting, gossip, and rumors), and social media. The fifth scale involves resources relevant to Sara's ontogenetic development as an individual. In what follows, we provide a case study of Sara's ontogenetic trajectory, showing how heterogeneous resources from these five scales become relevant as Sara comes to be identified as sexually promiscuous. We do not claim that these five scales capture all of the resources relevant to social identification in this case, but they represent central ones. The central conceptual point is that these resources form a contingent network, facilitating the social identification of Sara in this case. It is not simply that a macro-level stereotype gets applied to her. Instead, various resources come together to make her social identification possible.

Coming from Mexico, living in Marshall

Sara was born in Mexico and migrated to Marshall, PA with her parents in early childhood. They came in search of better employment opportunities, choosing Marshall because her aunt and cousins live there. Shortly after arriving, Sara's parents separated. Sara now lives with her mother, stepfather (also a Mexican immigrant), and younger sister. She does not know where her biological father is. Sara's family is low-income, despite the fact that her mother and stepfather both work multiple jobs. Sara lives in downtown Marshall in a small apartment with her nuclear family in a mixed black and Latino neighborhood.

Sara and her family came to Marshall in search of a better life. This reflects economic and migratory dynamics between the U.S. and Mexico as well as changing labor market patterns that have led Mexicans to settle in New Latino Diaspora areas over the past two decades (Zúñiga, Hernández-León, Shaddock-Hernández, & Villarreal, 2002). These dynamics include the widespread perception of the US as a site of economic opportunity. Stories of Mexicans who found economic success in the US circulate widely in Mexican communities. These stories and the longstanding history of migration were resources that facilitated Sara's family migration. In this way, Sara's ontogenetic trajectory was influenced by the history of domination and migration between the U.S. and Mexico. But did this longstanding history between the two countries contribute to Sara being identified as sexually promiscuous? It provided background context, but it did not directly shape her sexual identity. But

other longer timescale, more widely circulating resources, like cultural models of family and schooling in the US and Mexico, were directly relevant to her social identification. In some important ways her identification as sexually promiscuous was made possible by her transnational ontological trajectory and her exposure to both Mexican and U.S. cultural frameworks.

Processes and outcomes of social identification in NLD communities are often quite different than in regions of longstanding Latino presence (Wortham, Allard, Lee, & Mortimer, 2011; Hamann et al., 2002). In Marshall and other NLD locations, the rapid growth of the Mexican population creates indeterminacy and flexibility. Long-term residents and educators question who Mexican immigrants are, and Mexican immigrants must make sense of their own and others' identities in this new context (Wortham et al., 2009). In the NLD, longstanding residents often have less entrenched models about Latino newcomers (Hamann et al., 2002; Wortham et al., 2009). This increased flexibility for socially identifying Latinos in Marshall is one resource upon which Sara and others draw when socially identifying her. In Marshall, longstanding residents have limited experience with Mexicans, and they struggle to make sense of this unfamiliar group. They cast around for stereotypes in ways that do not occur in regions of longstanding Latino settlement. A stereotype like the "promiscuous Latina" can thus take hold and crowd out other models of personhood in a way that it probably would not elsewhere.

Starting school, discovering boys

Sara, like most Latina girls in her age group, arrived in Marshall in early childhood. She has attended Marshall schools since kindergarten. She was placed in English as a Second Language (ESL) classes to support the development of her English language proficiency. At age eight, Sara started third grade at Grant Elementary School (GES) and began developing romantic interests in boys. Halfway through her third grade year, she started "dating" a boy named José, a sixth grader who attended Marshall Middle School (MMS) and who she met in her neighborhood. "Dating" at this age involved hanging out at school, in the neighborhood, or at family or neighborhood parties. Sara's friends and her older cousin Louisa knew about this dating, but her parents did not. Sara's parents would have been upset to know that she was dating José, but her friends and cousin did not disparage Sara for dating in this way.

When Sara attended GES, the school served equal numbers of African American and Latino students, with few students from other backgrounds (NCES, 2010). In the lower grades Latinos were the majority, with over 70 percent of kindergartners coming from Spanish-speaking households. Spanish dominant students at Grant were integrated with other students for the majority of the school day and received ESL pullout services for 15–60 min several times per week. Although Sara spoke English fluently, without a Spanish-language accent, she was labeled as an ESL student and received services to assist her with English reading and writing. Approximately one third of Grant students were enrolled in ESL. All curricular materials and interactions were exclusively in English, except for those used by the pullout ESL teacher. The school did have a Spanish-speaking receptionist and a Latino administrator.

The demographics of her school and her ESL status both played a role in Sara's social identification. In our research at GES, MMS, and the local high school (Clonan-Roy, Rhodes & Wortham, 2013; Allard, Mortimer, Gallo, Link & Wortham, 2014; Gallo, Link, Allard, Wortham & Mortimer, 2014), we have shown that elementary teachers in these schools tend to have more positive ideologies about Latino students than middle and high school teachers. At GES, we have described an ideology of "English-plus": Educators see it as beneficial to maintain one's home language as long as a student learns English well. GES teachers often praised Mexican students as bilinguals-in-the-making and talked about the importance of Spanish (Gallo et al., 2014). In the earlier grades, where there is less academic pressure and fewer expectations that students enter school with English skills, Spanish-speakers are given space to learn English and Spanish is often considered to be a resource for learning (Gallo et al., 2014). Thus Sara's ESL status did not negatively influence her in elementary school. As Sara moved into middle school, however, this changed. In Marshall, being identified as "ESL" in middle school sometimes has negative implications for a student's academic success (Clonan-Roy et al., 2013). The significance of "ESL student" as a label shifts as students move from elementary to middle to high school. As Sara entered middle school and found herself perceived as less academically successful because of the ESL label, she moved from more local to more widely circulating ideologies about minoritized students—the less common asset-based account of Marshall elementary school teachers gave way to the more familiar deficit ideologies that dominated in middle school.

The account of ESL students as less academically successful that Sara encountered at MMS intersected with another ideology, one that associates various behaviors, in addition to being labeled as ESL, with lack of academic success. Sexual activity at an early age is one of these behaviors. Because Sara became associated with more than one activity that is taken to index a lack of academic success, she was positioned as an unpromising, "at risk" student. These heterogeneous resources—including misperceptions about her linguistic proficiency, stereotypes about English language learners, ideologies of minority girls as hypersexual, and the divergent perspectives across elementary and middle schools—converged to support an emerging account of her as a problematic student, amongst staff and her peers.

When Sara started dating boys in third grade, her cousin Louisa was seventeen, had already had a child, and had dropped out of school. When Louisa became pregnant, there were fewer school and community resources available to help her than there are now. Louisa had dated boys since early ages, and Sara liked talking to Louisa about José because Louisa listened to her and gave her advice. Louisa served as a model of sexuality and relationships for Sara. This model included early dating and sexual activity, dating older boys, and teen child rearing. Although Sara's mother disapproved of her dating boys at an early age, her mother had also had children at a young age. Sara's relationship with her mother is strained, but her mother and cousin's models are the only ones she knew.

Many other Latina girls in Marshall grew up in similar circumstances and with similar role models, but they did not begin to date boys so young. This shows that we are not simply applying a macro-level account of Latina girls across the board. In part, Sara was different because of agency, the decisions she herself made. In part she was different because a substantially older boy may have pressured her into a relationship. Despite dating at such a young age, however, Sara started out being well regarded by her peers. In elementary school and in her first year of middle school, Sara's closest friends were Latina. Like most other Latinas, she also had friendly relationships with girls and boys from a variety of ethnic backgrounds. In elementary school, the peer group is less relevant to individuals' evaluations of self-worth and in socially identifying "what individuals are like" because it is a less relational period of development (Nakkula & Toshalis, 2006; Sullivan, 1953). In elementary school, Sara's peers were less invested in monitoring peer group norms through gossip, rumors, and stories than they subsequently became. This is important because, despite her dating boys in elementary school, she was not socially identified as sexually promiscuous at that point. It was the convergence of a unique combination of resources in middle school, like ideologies about academic success and the types of behaviors associated with it, together with the early events in Sara's ontogenetic development, that combined to facilitate a cross-event trajectory in which Sara's identity as sexually promiscuous became increasingly solidified.

Moving to Marshall Middle School

Several years ago, Sara entered fifth grade at MMS. Before her arrival, staff had already become concerned about Latinas' romantic entanglements and sexual activities. When Sara was in fourth grade, an MMS administrator told one of us that Latina students dated older boys, engaged in sexual activities, and suffered sexual abuse at younger ages than girls from other ethnic groups. As a result, the administrator claimed, Latinas became less academically engaged during middle school. They acknowledged that school staff was struggling to support these students.

As a result of these concerns, Wortham and MMS leadership arranged for Clonan-Roy to facilitate a girls' group for Latina students. Before doing so, Clonan-Roy explored MMS staff member perspectives about Latina girls' sexual practices and academic achievement. In many formal and informal meetings at MMS, Clonan-Roy documented the following staff hypotheses about Latina girls (compiled from multiple fieldnotes and interviews that took place between 2011 and 2012):

MMS administrator:	Some Mexican families are out of touch with U.S. culture, customs, and laws, and because of this, they allow their daughters to date much older men. Mexican girls assimilate too quickly, which causes them to initiate sexual activity at earlier ages.
MMS ESL teacher:	Mexican family parties can cause problems because they allow older men to interact with younger girls and there is a lack of supervision. Crowded living conditions can lead to girls' interactions with older men, and that can be a factor in sexual abuse.
MMS community liaison:	Early sexual activity and pregnancy are modeled in some Mexican families by mothers, aunts, and other female family figures who have had babies at young ages. Many families are uneducated and do not value education as much as families who have experienced success through education.
MMS counselor:	Some families lack knowledge of contraception and/or do not believe in it because of religious reasons. Mexican adults often engage in physical fights, and thus Mexican girls think it is acceptable to resolve conflict with physical fights.

These folk theories present negative evaluations of Latina girls and their families. The evaluations draw on stereotypes that circulate more and less widely, at the scales of the larger society, the local community, and the local school. Staff supported their accounts with examples of students who had been dating older boys, having sex, dealing with a pregnancy scare, or surviving an act of sexual abuse. Educators connected these cases with widely circulating stereotypes about Latinas and built models of identity that were then available for socially identifying Sara. As described above, the social identification of Latinos in New Latino Diaspora communities is often more flexible than it is in longstanding Latino communities, and we have shown this to be the case in Marshall (e.g., Wortham et al., 2009). While stereotypes of Latina youth as sexually promiscuous had not robustly taken hold in the larger Marshall community, they had become established among educators and students at MMS and in the larger school district. These local resources were crucial to the Sara's ontogenetic trajectory.

Other researchers have documented similar stereotypes of Latinas, which position them as making poor choices, dropping out of school, becoming teenage mothers, engaging in romantic relationships with gang members, and being hypersexual and exotic (Denner & Guzman, 2006; Lundström, 2006; Rolon-Dow, 2004). Collins (1991) describes how intersecting stereotypes involving race, class, gender, and sexuality have yielded these images of women of color. These objectify women of color as "other" and are often "constructed in contrast to white women and values associated with white women, like piety, purity, submissiveness, and domesticity" (Collins, 1991, p. 76). As we have described, such stereotypes were not uniformly espoused in Marshall or the local schools, but they did circulate densely in the middle school. In some spaces in Marshall, sexualized media images of Latina women often shape perceptions and interactions within schools (Lundström, 2006; Rolon-Dow, 2004). For instance, in the quotes above the MMS counselor and community liaison both employ common, gendered, sexualized stereotypes about Latinas. They claim that a lack of knowledge about contraception, models of early sexuality, and a lack of appreciation for education cause Latinas to make bad choices. The MMS administrator describes Latino cultural practices, positioning Mexican migrant families as out of touch with appropriate behavior in the U.S. context. In their attempt to explain Latina girls' "early" sexual activity, the administrator echoes an anxiety that many Latino immigrant parents have:

assimilation to American cultural practices leads to an increase in Latina girls' promiscuity (Cammarota, 2004; Suárez-Orozco & Suárez-Orozco, 2002). Latino parents often strictly monitor their daughters in the U.S. to ensure that they are not adopting "American promiscuity." Note how the educators and the parents locate the source of this alleged behavior differently—with educators locating it in working class Mexican culture and parents locating it in mainstream American culture.

MMS educators do not describe all Latina girls as sexually promiscuous. Academically successful Latinas and many who are not regularly disciplined are not identified in this way. But staff nonetheless experience moral panic about Latina girls' sexuality. Stevenson (2012) describes how low-income girls of color's bodies, thoughts and actions are often understood "through the lenses of moral panic, poverty, protection, and sexual risk," and they are "policed by national and local political narratives, public policies, and individual interactions with peers, family, and public schools" (p. 4). Stevenson argues that public concern over black and Latina girls' sexuality is motivated by a "societal state of frenzied being, where national, local, and/or group norms are disrupted by an episode, person, or group of persons that are identified as threats to one's lived experience," or to society's agreed-on "respectable behavior and civilized ways of being" (p. 12). The moral panic at MMS affects how staff members understand and interact with Latina students. They, in turn, shape the way in which Sara was understood once she arrived at MMS.

At MMS, staff's primary concern is academic. Staff are not generally concerned with students' sexuality or moral development, but instead with making sure that sexual activities do not detract from academic success. Academically successful girls are not identified as sexually promiscuous, regardless of their behaviors. But girls who are perceived as sexually active are seen as academically unsuccessful. Panic about lack of academic success influences how girls like Sara are understood at MMS.

Skipping school, becoming sexually active

In elementary school Sara dated boys, but educators and peers did not identify her as sexually promiscuous. As described above, elementary school girls do not gossip as much, and they did not use social media to evaluate each other. Sara's elementary school also lacked the moral panic about Latina sexuality and academic success. Sara became identified as sexually promiscuous during her first year at MMS. One key resource that facilitated this social identification was the staff stereotypes described above. Sara went from an elementary school environment in which educators displayed positive models of bilingualism and Latino personhood to a middle school with very different models.

At MMS, teachers no longer positively evaluated Latino students' Spanish use and often only drew upon their Spanish-language knowledge when having a problem communicating English-language content (Clonan-Roy et al., 2013). Students faced increased expectations for their English and Spanish language proficiency because of the increased rigor of academic work and the standardized testing regimes. Teachers understood students' Spanish language use, and especially Latina girls' Spanish language use, within the broader context in which teachers perceive these students—as less innocent, as more threatening and/or at-risk, as non-normative, and as adult beings who are responsible for their actions. At the high school, bilingual students are often evaluated as speaking neither English nor Spanish well (Allard et al., 2014; Rosa, 2010). This language ideology often yields negative evaluations of students' cognitive abilities. In middle school, Sara and her peers faced this shift from positive to negative evaluations of Spanish speakers, Latinos, and ESL students, as middle school teachers mobilized resources from broader scales in order to socially identify the Latinas.

At the start of Sara's first year at MMS, she had many good friends and a positive social reputation. She and José had broken up, and Sara "talked to" other boys. In March of her fifth grade year, Sara started talking to her ex-boyfriend José (then in eighth grade). He was dating Elena, but Sara snuck out of her house at night to go on walks with him. One day in March, Sara decided to skip an entire day of school with José. Sara later claimed that she skipped school to "make out" with him and have fun. This event turned out to be pivotal in Sara's social identification as a sexually promiscuous girl. Thus something that happened at a relatively short timescale—the event and the subsequent construals of it over the next weeks and months—strongly influenced Sara's ontogenetic trajectory.

Sara was able to skip school because of her parents' taxing work schedules and because she did not live with extended family as she would have in Mexico. Sara's mother found out that Sara skipped school with José because one of their neighbors saw Sara walking with him in the neighborhood during school hours and told her mother. Her mother turned to MMS for help. The following emails (copied to administrators, Sara's counselor, teachers, and Clonan-Roy) reflect staff perspectives on Sara skipping school to be with José:

Good Afternoon,

Late yesterday, Sara's mother and stepfather came in to share some concerns. Specifically, her dating an older boy (an 8th grader) and the potential decisions she may be making with him. This relationship has caused Sara to miss a day of school, and on several occasions she has sneaked out of the home.

Here is what I was able to offer the family;

- 1) I will meet with the young man to discourage his advances toward Sara
- 2) I informed Sara that she is to ride her identified bus (it seems on occasion she has gone on to other buses)

- 3) I would communicate this to those that work with, teach or interact with Sara (hence this email)—I can provide more information about last night's conversation if you would like to see me.

In our conversation last night, Sara communicated that she does want to be successful and is interested in being promoted to the next grade.

MMS administrator

-----Email response to the MMS administrator's email-----

Good afternoon all,

From my perspective, Sara likes to give adults a bit of "shock value." She seems to enjoy that kind of attention. I've only briefly spoken with her mother on a few occasions, but I know that relationship is strained.

She's a very smart girl, but she's using her intelligence against herself right now. Her choices are putting her in pretty dangerous situations that will eventually have gravely serious consequences that I (and I think the rest of you will agree) don't believe she's anywhere close to ready for. We've got to find a more constructive outlet for her.

I'm going to approach her with a journaling idea (one I discussed with her at the beginning of the year) and we'll see where she goes from there.

MMS ESL teacher

These emails were crucial to MMS educators' identifications of Sara. Although educators knew that Sara enjoyed male attention and had a strained relationship with her mother, this is the first time that staff identified Sara as potentially sexually promiscuous and willing to risk academic success for male attention. The moral panic about sexual activities of low-income Latina girls and their academic failure—partly drawn from widely circulating stereotypes and partly specific to MMS—allowed the educators to frame Sara's choices as sexual, dangerous, and likely to undermine academic success. The panic was reinforced by Sara's family's anxiety about her sexuality. Although Sara told her mom that she and José "only made out," Sara's mother told MMS administrators that Sara and José had sex. Many Mexican parents have strict rules and high anxiety about their daughters' sexuality (Cammarota, 2004; Garcia, 2009b; Suárez-Orozco, Baolian Qin, & Fruja Amthor, 2008). Sara's mother may have reported the event as sex in order to scare her daughter into compliance, because she feared that all was lost in this regard; or she may have done so because her parental anxiety surrounding Sara's sexual promiscuity led her to believe that Sara was lying and actually did have sex.

School and family circumstances also led Sara's mother to turn to MMS for help, and this choice directly affected Sara's social identification as sexually promiscuous in school. The Marshall School District has worked to reach the Latino community, hiring Latino community liaisons, partnering with Latino non-profit organizations, and providing interpreters to encourage parental participation. These efforts may have made Sara's mother feel more comfortable turning to the school for help. When Sara's mother reported the incident to the school, the event changed from being one event in an individual's life, to an issue discussed in the family (Sara's parents and other relatives became involved), to something known at a community scale (because of the neighbor's observation and subsequent reports to others), to a story and emerging social fact at the school, where the event generated a disciplinary meeting with an administrator and subsequent emails among school staff. Once the event was written into an email, it circulated more widely. As the MMS administrator indicated, those details could also be shared with other staff members who wanted to know more. The movement of this information between community members, Sara's family, and school staff began a cross-event trajectory involving multiple speech events that were taken up and presupposed in subsequent events, more robustly establishing Sara's identification as sexually promiscuous and at risk of academic failure.

The email exchanges also reveal a tension between her mother's and educators' concerns for Sara. Sara's mother focused on her moral development, turning to the school because she was concerned that her daughter was dishonest and engaged in inappropriate sexual activity. This probably reflected a Mexican cultural value of *educación*, one that encompasses "additional, nonacademic dimensions, such as learning the difference between right and wrong, respect for parents and others, and correct behavior, which parents view as the base upon which all other learning lies" (Reese, Balzano, Gallimore, & Goldenberg, 1995, p. 66). This widespread model of moral personhood sees moral upbringing as a precursor to academic success. However, the MMS administrator's and ESL teacher's emails seem more focused on academic success, without focusing on moral concerns. In the U.S., academic success is not necessarily tied to moral personhood. Staff members expressed their concern that Sara missed a day of school and was using her intelligence against herself, and they discussed how to help her be academically successful and advance to the next grade. The school responded to Sara's mother's concerns in so far as it felt that Sara's academic success was at risk. Both Sara's mother and the school addressed Sara skipping school to be with a boy, and both wanted to help Sara, but they had different agendas and Sara's skipping school meant different things to each party. While Sara's mother and school staff had different reasons for addressing Sara's behavior, they were able to find common ground in defining her behavior as negative. Sara had great difficulty contesting these social identifications. Resources from multiple scales—not all of which she has access to—were mobilized for different reasons and in different ways, and they came together to identify her as promiscuous and at risk.

Rumors circulating, continuing sexual activity

Sara was very upset following the disciplinary meeting described in the MMS administrator's email. She said that her mom was a "bitch" for saying "all of this embarrassing stuff" in front of school staff (Fieldnote, 03/16/12). Sara's embarrassment grew in the following weeks as rumors begin to circulate among her peers. The week after Sara skipped school, Clonan-Roy had lunch with two girls' group members, Yari and Mia, who spoke about Sara's actions (Interview, 03/02/12). The girls' comments were prompted by Clonan-Roy's question: "What is difficult about being a girl in middle school?"

- Y: Like, uh, your mom or your dad is not going to like that you have a boyfriend.
M: Dealing with people like best friends and all that.
C-R: Ya. What happens with best friends?
M: Um, sometimes they um do things with your boyfriend.
C-R: Does that happen a lot?
M: (smiling) Um, maybe it happened to somebody... in our group... Not me.
C-R: Not you?... Was that the cause of the drama between Sara and Cecilia?
M: No, Sara and Elena.
C-R: Really?
Y: Sara, she like, um, missed school on, on Thursday or Wednesday because she said she um was in bed with Sara's boyfriend...
M: No, Elena's.
C-R: Oh, Elena's boyfriend? Wait, did Sara say that or did people say that about Sara?
M: Sara said it.
C-R: Wait... how... I mean, where would Sara and this guy go? Are their parents not home during the day or something?
Y: Um... her mom works a lot.
M: (mumbles something)
C-R: Wait, what was that?
Y: She's going to skip school next Thursday to do it again.
C-R: To go where though?
Y: I don't know.
C-R: But you think her mom works a lot and maybe they just go to her house?
M: She told me that.
Y: And her dad... he goes too... Her, her... step dad, um, her step dad... he goes a lot... to um work...
C-R: Would you guys ever skip school to be with a boy?
Y: No.

Her peer group plays a central role in Sara's social identity. Sara and her friends police their peers through gossip, rumors, and evaluative narratives. They also employ emotional tactics like shame, humiliation, and social isolation to discipline girls who violate peer group codes of conduct. These types of evaluations are made based on their value systems, which are influenced by cultural models from various scales (e.g., images and evaluations from national media about Latinas; widely-circulating ideologies about girlhood and sexuality; family and cultural ideologies surrounding girlhood, sexuality, and age appropriate behavior; and beliefs about schooling and achievement). Yari and Mia draw on these resources when discussing Sara's alleged actions. They point out norms that Sara has breached, and they judge her. Yari points out that parents do not permit girls to have boyfriends. Not having a boyfriend at this age is a peer group norm, one that is shaped by cultural and family practices, school expectations, and peer values. Mia identifies another peer group value—fidelity to friends—and criticizes Sara for betraying her friend Elena. These peer group resources (gossip, rumors, evaluative narratives, peer group value systems) have particular force at Sara and her peers' developmental stage of early adolescence, in which the peer group functions as a central means for learning about the self and others (Nakkula & Toshalis, 2006; Sullivan, 1953).

Later that week, Clonan-Roy met with Sara, who reflected on the aftermath of skipping school with José, the rumors that were circulating, and the change in her social position (Fieldnote, 03/16/12):

Sara told me that she was "really embarrassed" because her mother had said "all this stuff" about her and boys in front of one the MMS administrators. She reflected upon all of the relational problems she was having. She claimed that she hated her mom and frequently fought with her and called her a "bitch." She also said that since the incident she has felt "bad" at school because people have been spreading rumors about her having sex and that people, including people that she thought were her friends, were calling her a "slut," a "bitch," and a "prostitute." I asked how she felt when she was with José, knowing that he had a girlfriend, and she said that she knows it is bad and wrong and that she is going to try to change.

Sara's actions with José affected her personal relationships, the way she was identified in her school community, and her sense of self. Because she betrayed her close friend Elena, the peer group was very upset with Sara, identifying her as sexually promiscuous, and they spread rumors about her being a "slut" in order to isolate her. The punishment she received from her parents, MMS staff, and her peer group made her start to feel like a "bad girl." The rumors about the incident between Sara and José did not damage José's social reputation or his personal relationships. Although Sara claimed that she did not in fact have sex with José, she was unable to change the narrative that circulated about her. Her version could not compete with her peers' narratives, which were taken up and reaffirmed. These stories also circulated among school staff and Sara's family. This circulation also took place at another scale—weeks and months long trajectories of circulation through relatively local communities. The rumors that circulated about Sara drew on but did not simply instantiate more

widely circulating stereotypes. As Sara transitioned to sixth grade, the negative peer evaluation followed her and reinforced her social identification as sexually promiscuous and academically unsuccessful.

Reinforcing a trajectory of social identification across the grades

In Sara's sixth grade year, she started talking to a seventh grade boy named David. She sent a text message to him with a picture of her naked breasts. David was in the boys locker room with friends when he received the image. One of the friends, Roman, stole David's phone and posted the image on Facebook as a "joke." Before Facebook removed the post for inappropriate content, many of Sara's peers saw the image. MMS administrators also found out about the post and had disciplinary meetings with Sara, David, and Roman. Sara had to meet with her counselor who tried to engage Sara in a discussion about her motivations for sending the image, why it was inappropriate, and the dangers of sending such pictures.

This incident revived old rumors about Sara and reinforced many staff members' and students' perceptions of her as sexually promiscuous. For weeks, students discussed how Sara "was a slut" and "had been exposed." Although MMS administrators disciplined David and Roman, they did not receive the same peer "slut-shaming" as Sara. The widely circulating, gendered, cultural model of the "slut" often leads girls to be shamed for sexual activities while their male partners are elevated (Dietrich, 1998; Garcia, 2009a). As in the situation with José, David's social reputation remained untarnished, and he went on to date many of the girls who ostracized Sara for her behavior.

These rumors had a lasting influence on Sara's social position. Later in her sixth grade year she started talking to an eighth grade boy named Luis. Although Sara insisted that she was not having sex with boys, her peers thought that she was. Three 8th grade Latina girls told Clonan-Roy the following story about Sara (Fieldnote, 04/18/12):

Lilia said that Sara "went to bed" with Lilia's ex-boyfriend, Luis, and now Sara was pregnant. I asked if that story was going around school and they said "yes." Michelle said that lots of stories go around about Sara because "she is a sl. . . ." She trailed off and Lilia said, "Just say it." Michelle said, "Ok, she is a slut." Emma then added, "and she's only in sixth grade!"

Sara's social identification as a "slut" followed her across grades at MMS. As Sara's peers told and retold stories about her engaging in sexual acts and violating peer norms, they reinforced her reputation as sexually promiscuous. Sara's actions with David and Luis were read in light of her skipping school with José in fifth grade and subsequent accounts of that event. Her trajectory of social identification became more rigid and more difficult to escape as similar social identifications were made of her across events and became more solid. Sara's behavior did not change dramatically, as she had consistently dated boys and engaged in some degree of sexual activities with them since third grade. Instead, there was a change in how her behaviors were interpreted across different contexts. Because the context in elementary school was not the same as the context in the middle school, her behaviors were not interpreted the same way in both places. Her social identification as promiscuous and academically unsuccessful became increasingly sedimented, as resources from various scales (e.g., society, school, peer, and family) were mobilized by a variety of actors across events.

Following Sara forward, imagining a future for Latina girls at MMS

As we write this article, Sara is in her last year at MMS. She has only a few close friends, frequently curses at teachers, and has threatened to fight many of her former friends. Although Sara has privately expressed shame to Clonan-Roy and her counselor, she is outwardly aggressive, and this intensifies the circulation of rumors about her, her reputation as sexually promiscuous, and her social isolation.

Many of her former friends now scorn her and circulate stories about her being promiscuous. For instance, a group of 8th grade girls (Lara, Izzy, Kemmy, Ali, Melanie, Yarely, and Emily) recently discussed Sara with Clonan-Roy (Group Interview, 06/25/14):

- L: Sara didn't like Kelli, and Sara wanted Ingrid to have problems with Kelli too.
M: Nobody here like her. You like her? You like her? (Looking around the room)
I: I told my mom about what happened with Sara. . . . She said. . . . My mom told me to fuck her up. That's what she said.
C-R: Why? What do people say about her at school?
L: She a ho. She think she cute.
C-R: Why do you say that?
K: Alright, so last year. . . . There's this kid named David, right? I guess she sent him nudes. And I guess she got exposed.
I: Yup!
A: Oooooo.
Y: Because, didn't they steal his phone? . . . Someone in the boy's locker room. And then they posted it on Facebook.
A: Yup!
L: (to A, her younger sister) How do you even know this?!
A: Because you told me! You told my mom!
L: Oh ya, I did (laughter erupts). And my mom yelled at me. She was like, "I don't want you to hang out with that girl!"
C-R: Oh, so some parents found out too?
E: Ya, like that one lady. . . . I think she's your tía [aunt].
C-R: So what happened after this Sara thing? Like, how did she act at school?
L: She has no friends now. She has like three friends.

- I: They're all morenas.
L: Ya, they're bl... (trails off)
M: (Quietly trying to count and name Sara's possible friends)
E: Ya, but Amaya be fake with her. Cuz she be tellin' me stuff about her.

This conversation shows how the narratives about Sara spread beyond school to other girls' parents. They construed Sara for their own purposes, as an example of how not to behave. Lara told her mom about Sara being "exposed" by her peers, and Emily and Izzy mention adults who have talked about Sara and evaluated her negatively. Sara's social identification thus moved beyond the spatial scale of the school, out into the community.

At MMS, Latina girls' close friend groups are often racially segregated and, although Latina girls have black and white acquaintances, their close friend groups typically include only Latina girls. The seven girls who talk about Sara in the last excerpt, and who were Sara's close friends in fifth grade, form such a group. These Latina girls often contrast themselves with the "white girls," whom they characterize as lame, studious, and conservative, and the "*morenas*" or "black girls," whom they characterize as dirty, poor, ghetto, and more sexually promiscuous than Latina girls. There is a small population of Afro-Latinas (mostly girls with parents from the Dominican Republic) at MMS, but Afro-Latinas are most often ostracized by the "black girls" for their low-level English fluency. They tend to join Latina peer groups, and other Latina girls do not describe them as *morenas*.

The girls' racialized friendship groups are built upon community racial dynamics in Marshall, which are influenced by widely circulating social discourses about whites, blacks and Latinos. The Latina girls position Sara's behaviors negatively—as more like a "*morena*" than a "*Latina*"—tapping into a local model of personhood in Marshall, one that holds that Mexicans are "model minorities" and blacks are inferior to them (Wortham et al., 2009). At MMS, Latina girls say that black and white girls position Latina girls as the "sluttiest" group in school. Latina girls contest this by claiming that they "keep their virginity" until older ages than do girls from other groups. In doing so, they draw on a model of idealized Latina sexual personhood, which allows them to contest the stereotype of Latinas as sexually promiscuous. Unfortunately for Sara, she became an object lesson about how not to be Latina, as girls used her story to reinforce these racial boundaries. Thus racialized and gendered resources from society, community, family, and peer scales converged to apply a racialized ideology about sexual promiscuity to Sara, casting her as more like a sexually promiscuous "*morena*."

Conclusions

The work that goes into socially identifying Sara and other Latina girls at MMS has strong effects because, as Reese (2001) shows, Mexican youth often make life-course decisions between the ages of 12 and 18. While Latino "[p]arents see their responsibility as that of giving their children the knowledge necessary for them to follow the 'good path' in life. . . , children make the decision for themselves" (Reese, 2001, p. 67). The social identifications of Latina girls at MMS shape who these girls will become.

Heterogeneous resources from societal, community, school, family, peer, and individual scales come together to allow Sara, her family, peers, and school staff to identify her across her elementary and middle school careers. We have described how contingent configurations of resources from various scales came together over time, as Sara traveled a developmental pathway from a more typical Latina to someone who was ostracized, nonnormative, and sexually promiscuous. Some of the key events in her trajectory and her social identification were contingent, and across her trajectory of identification she and others deployed resources ranging from widely circulating gendered and racial stereotypes to more local models and practices. There were various social actors contributing to these processes, and they had varying amounts of power to influence Sara's social identification. As models of her spread across scales, they became more widely recognizable and harder to contest. It would be more convenient for analysts if the same configuration of resources—like a predictable combination of "micro" and "macro"—always led to a given phenomenon like the social identification of Latina girls. But this is not the case. Analysts must attend to the heterogeneous configuration of resources from various scales that are relevant to a given case in order to uncover the sometimes-unusual configurations that make a social process possible.

This contingency and heterogeneity leave room for unexpected actions. As we have shown, Mexican girls at MMS contest models of Latina-ness that circulate at societal and school scales. As Latina girls navigate multiple cultural frameworks, it is possible that we will see a shift in how they and others think about the relationship between moral personhood and academic success. At MMS, academic engagement and success are important to Latinas. They also value some aspects of more traditional Mexican models of moral personhood. Perhaps Latina students' assimilation to U.S. culture is in fact aligning them more closely with school values of academic success instead of accelerating their sexuality, as the MMS administrator suggested. Middle school students can become social actors who can shape and challenge dominant models of identity, as they work with heterogeneous configurations of resources in particular settings.

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